

Senior Healthcare Perspective

“A Crisis in Healthcare “

The membership of Alberta Seniors United Now (SUN) is becoming very concerned regarding their current access to healthcare services and to the Healthcare systems ability to respond in a timely and efficient manner.

At present, there are over 800 long term patients in active treatment hospitals. They are there because they have failed in the community and have nowhere else to go to receive the health assistance they require. These individuals would prefer to receive continuing health services in the community or at best, in an appropriate continuing care facility. They cannot, as these health delivery services are plugged and do not have the capacity to respond to their needs. These frail seniors therefore remain in an active treatment bed. This is the most expensive alternative. This is not where frail seniors expect to receive care, nor should they.

The healthcare system is completely overflowing with demand and cannot respond appropriately. Seniors should not be classified as “bed blockers” that are plugging up the system. They occupy active treatment beds because they do not have any other options. They require continuing care and must go to the facility that can accept them. This is the fault of the system, not the seniors. It is the system that is broken.

The creation of a single health super board appears to have made things worse. Nothing has been fixed since its creation. It is not more efficient and is not more cost effective. More funds are not flowing to health care. Needs are increasing as Albertans age, yet resources are not flowing to need. This is a sure formula for disaster. In fact, it appears that saving dollars is the objective not properly funding the health care system.

The Alberta Health Services Board has taken a series of disastrous decisions in relation to mental-health care, primary health care, long term care and staffing levels that have had a cascade reaction on Alberta’s emergency departments and hospital wards. These decisions adversely affect seniors care in Alberta.

The SUN members are deeply concerned with the current health delivery system. We fail to see any remedies to these problems being put into place. In fact, we see the opposite. The Alberta Government has frozen long term beds at 14,500. Albertans now face a minimum wait of at least two years before new beds can be constructed and brought into the system. This is a serious planning mistake. Health Centres, while completed, are not fully operational or staffed. They are not there to respond to need. This also raises the question of how effectively; AHS is planning for the future. It appears planning is purely cost saving, not patient outcome focused. Health care is the right of all Albertans and it desperately needs positive and creative attention.

There is also an increasing problem with access to the emergency departments of Alberta hospitals. They are full and need exceeds capacity. All Albertans are being subjected to long waits for medical attention and then long waits on an emergency stretcher before a bed becomes available. This situation is particularly acute for frail seniors. It has negative impacts on their health status. Our emergency departments must do better.

Each day, more and more seniors are requesting home care support. It appears, to us seniors, that funding and staffing is not increasing, therefore seniors are slowly failing. It is evident that more funds need to be injected into home care to prevent further deterioration of seniors who in turn will further plug up our emergency departments and our active treatment hospitals. The health care crisis is alarming. Seniors are becoming anxious and fearful that health services will not be available when they need it.

What is needed now is practical action to improve access to home care, long term care, primary health care and emergency response times. We must restore common sense and good judgement to the delivery of health care before the problems get out of hand and require a massive infusion of funds to correct. Extensive reliance on the "For Profit" sector to solve these problems is not a fiscally responsible answer, as neither seniors nor the Alberta tax payer can afford these high priced solutions

The seniors of Alberta strongly urge the government to make health care service delivery your number one priority. You need to proceed immediately to correct the urgent problems you have created. We also ask that you include seniors in all planning processes that are underway to ensure our voice is heard and that our needs are your priority.